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IARCO RESEARCH PROPOSAL

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Research Topic: A Neuroscience-Informed Digital Wellness Platform for Supporting Emotional Well-Being Among Adolescents Aged 12–15



StudentHaven: A Customizable Neuroscience-Informed Digital Wellness Platform for Adolescents Aged 12–15 Across Diverse Educational Environments

Introduction: Adolescence is a crucial stage in everyone's life for emotional and neurological development. When students, especially in junior high school, reach this stage, their brains undergo critical structural and functional neurodevelopment, particularly in brain regions responsible for cognitive control and emotional processing. Inside the brain, the amygdala, a limbic system structure involved in emotional reactivity and threat detection, develops earlier than the prefrontal cortex (PFC). In handling emotions and executive functions, the PFC is very important. Because of this developmental imbalance occurring in the brain, while the PFC continues to develop, adolescents may experience heightened vulnerability to stress and heightened emotional sensitivity at the same time. This may affect their everyday functioning, sleep efficiency, relationships, academic life, and mental well-being [1], [2].

Many adolescents nowadays experience various mental health challenges, with suicide being one of the leading causes of death [3], making this a crucial problem worldwide. In the Philippines, about 27.8% of school-going Filipino adolescents were reported to experience psychological distress, and in Bangladesh, 30.1% of school-going adolescents in different rural, semi-urban, and urban areas of Dhaka were found to experience moderate to severe depressive symptoms [4], [5]. Over time, technology has also become an important part of students' educational experiences and daily lives. Many schools, including De La Salle University Integrated School (DLSU-IS) in the Philippines, incorporate digital technology and online resources for the betterment of their students' learning. With this, as time goes on, many students nowadays have greater exposure to the internet. Though technology provides students with numerous opportunities for communication, their learning, and access to more information, it may also expose many to inappropriate or harmful online content and experiences that can negatively affect their emotional well-being. Social media, online interactions, misinformation, cyberbullying, and other potentially harmful content may contribute to stress, emotional distress, or unhealthy perceptions among young users [6]. As students continue to explore the internet and what it could offer them, there is still a need for age-appropriate and accessible digital resources to help them understand themselves more when it comes to their emotions, self-regulation practices, and recognizing when they may need to seek help from trusted adults or professionals [7]. There may already be existing guidance and counseling services and/or resources that several schools around the world may offer;

students may still experience difficulty in recognizing when it is actually the best time to seek support or knowing where to access appropriate and useful resources [7].

Many digital interventions, such as applications and websites that offer mental health support, have limitations, and their effectiveness for adolescents varies [7]. Many are also designed for general audiences, so they may not connect with school guidance services or reflect the culture, language, and resources of a particular school. Furthermore, schools differ in their available support systems, resources, cultures, languages, and student needs. Therefore, a digital wellness platform designed for only one school may not be easily adaptable to other educational environments. This creates a need for a platform that maintains a consistent, neuroscience-informed foundation while allowing schools to customize relevant resources and connect students with their existing guidance, counselling, or student-support systems.

Existing Literature: The amygdala may be small in our brain, but it plays a vital role in controlling our emotions and behaviour. One of the emotions the amygdala is known to regulate is fear. As it analyzes and processes everything we see and hear, it helps us understand what aspects of our lives are considered "dangerous" or safe to us. Located within the temporal lobe, the amygdala is a paired structure with one on each side of our brain. It consists of neurons that transmit electrical and chemical signals to our brain, while glial cells act as the "caretakers" of our neurons because of all the essential maintenance tasks they do around the neurons. There are several psychiatric or neurological conditions, such as brain tumours and anxiety disorders, that could impact our amygdala. The amygdala is crucial in understanding our own emotions and developing better self-regulation [8]. Working in collaboration with the amygdala is the Prefrontal Cortex (PFC), which is located within the frontal lobe of our brain. To ensure that our brain will function properly, the PFC also contains many parts: the dorsolateral prefrontal cortex (dlPFC) to assist us in both problem-solving and memory skills, the anterior cingulate cortex (ACC) to help us in regulating emotions, the ventromedial prefrontal cortex (vmPFC) for us to be able to analyze our emotions, the orbitofrontal cortex (OFC) for our decision-making skills, and the medial prefrontal cortex (mPFC), which helps us control our behaviour. Unlike other areas of our brain that help control emotions, the PFC develops much more slowly, with structural alterations and myelination continuing during adolescence and into the early years of adulthood. In the PFC, one may find that myelination is a biological process in the brain where nerve fibers, also known as neuronal axons, are wrapped in a myelin sheath that allows brain cells to communicate more efficiently and rapidly. This ongoing developmental process leads to different variations in one's emotional reactivity and cognitive control during adolescence, as the PFC is still maturing its ability to regulate emotions and guide decision-making. Just like the amygdala, the PFC is very important to understand, as it helps us know what causes these emotions and how to better regulate them [1], [2], [9].

As individuals reach the adolescent stage in their lives, they may start to face a lot of challenges as they transition from childhood to young adulthood due to a number of developmental changes that take place in their brain on a hormonal, emotional, and cognitive level. They may also experience difficulty dealing with various situations and controlling their own emotions, causing them to be more vulnerable to stress as they

adapt to new social, academic, and emotional challenges while their cognitive control systems are still developing [1], [2], [9]. Since adolescents are still developing, mental wellness resources should be presented to them using easy-to-understand educational strategies that would fit their age group. Simplified visual illustrations, neuroscience information, interactive content, and more would be best to help students have a better grasp of how their brain influences them in their daily lives. Students can benefit from learning that their prefrontal cortex (PFC) is still maturing, which can help them regulate their emotions and make more thoughtful decisions. Through these age-appropriate strategies, not only would it help the students understand who they are more, but also help schools support and connect with them more. These interventions may offer self-help tools and educational resources, but they shouldn't be used as a replacement for professional mental health services. Student-centered interventions encourage students to seek help in partnership with school guidance counselors and other mental health professionals [7].

These limitations suggest a need for a digital mental wellness website, called "StudentHaven", designed for students undergoing adolescence that helps them better understand and manage their emotions, guides them in recognizing when they may need to seek help, features neuroscience-based mental health information, and serves as a support or complement to existing school guidance services [7].

Research Aim: This research study aims to develop StudentHaven, a customizable, neuroscience-based digital wellness website, designed to support the emotional wellness of adolescents between the ages of 12 and 15, specifically junior high school students. The study will first be implemented and tested at De La Salle University Integrated School in the Philippines, where it will take the form of a customized website called AniHaven, using the StudentHaven template and connecting the school's values and community to the website as well. If the initial implementation is successful, the StudentHaven template may serve as a foundation for future adaptation by other institutions and schools, allowing them to customize the platform according to their own communities, resources, and student needs. StudentHaven is not intended to replace professional counselling or the existing guidance services of a school; it functions as a supplementary support tool only for the students, which can provide students with an accessible space to learn about their emotions, practice self-regulation strategies, and identify appropriate avenues for seeking help from trusted adults or professionals [7].

The study aims to address the following question:

RESEARCH QUESTION: How useful is AniHaven in helping adolescents aged 12-15 understand their emotions, practice self-regulation, and seek timely support?

HYPOTHESIS: It is hypothesized that adolescents aged 12-15 will find AniHaven useful for understanding their emotions, practicing self-regulation, and recognizing when to seek timely support, with a mean of 4.0 or higher on the 5-point Likert scale in each area.

Proposed Methodology:

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1. **Research Methods:** The study will utilize a mixed-methods research design to explore the DLSU-IS JHS students' experiences and perceptions of AniHaven. AniHaven will be implemented for two weeks before participants are asked to complete a feedback form using Google Forms.
    - Quantitative Data: Rating scales (5-point Likert scale) to measure the perceived usefulness of AniHaven in helping students understand their emotions, practice self-regulation, and recognize when to seek timely support. Accessibility and ease of navigation of the website will also be measured.
    - Qualitative Data: Open-ended response fields for students to share specific insights, personal feedback, suggestions, and overall user experiences.
2. **Website Development:** AniHaven will be developed using Google Sites as its primary website platform, with HTML and CSS used to customize its design and interactive elements. The website will be developed and coordinated with the DLSU-IS IT Office and Guidance and Counselling Unit (GCU). The website will contain several features intended to provide students with accessible educational and self-reflection resources. These include daily self-affirmations and a breathing exercise helping students calm down and regulate their emotions [10], [11], a daily mood check-in containing easy-to-understand neuroscience-related educational content explaining why they feel certain emotions(happy, sad, angry, scared, and disgusted) and how to control them, a personal journal and an external self-assessment resource that can help students reflect on whether they may need additional support and guide them toward seeking help when appropriate, and lastly, emergency and school support contacts helping students call certain professionals immediately just by clicking their phone numbers, whether they need mental support, police assistance, or more localized support in the school's area.
3. **Participants:** The participants of the initial testing will consist of 30–50 volunteer DLSU-IS Junior High School students.
4. **Data Collection:** After using AniHaven participants will complete a structured feedback form. The quantitative section of the form will use a 5-point Likert scale to evaluate AniHaven's perceived usefulness in helping students understand their emotions, practice self-regulation, and recognize when to seek timely support. Accessibility and ease of navigation will also be measured. The qualitative section will allow participants to describe their experiences, provide suggestions, and identify features of the website that they found useful or that could be improved. The collected responses will then be examined to determine the students' perceptions of AniHaven and to identify common feedback regarding the website's accessibility, usefulness, and overall user experience. The students' open-ended answers will be reviewed for recurring feedback and themes, while their Likert-scale answers will be summarized using descriptive statistics.
5. **Research Timeline:** The study will be conducted within four months during one academic school year. The first month will focus on developing the website and coordinating with the DLSU-IS IT Office and GCU. The second month will

involve the two-week testing period, followed immediately by the feedback form. The third month will focus on collecting and analyzing all the feedback through the survey, while the fourth month will be used to synthesize the findings and coordinate with the appropriate DLSU-IS offices for further implementation.

Ethical Considerations: Since the participants are minors, parental or guardian consent and participant assent will be obtained before the study. Participation is voluntary, and students may withdraw at any time without consequences. All feedback will remain anonymous and confidential, with no personally identifying data collected. The study will follow the Philippine Data Privacy Act of 2012 [12]. AniHaven will also clearly state that it is an educational and self-reflection website and does not provide professional or clinical treatment or assessment.

Conclusion: Adolescence is an important developmental stage in which students undergo significant neurological, cognitive, and emotional changes. Developmental processes, especially involving the amygdala and the PFC, during this period may create challenges in emotional regulation and stress management, highlighting the need for accessible and age-appropriate digital wellness resources [1], [2], [3]. StudentHaven is designed to support students by providing neuroscience-informed educational and self-reflection resources while complementing existing school guidance services. The platform will be implemented and tested first at DLSU-IS as AniHaven. Using a mixed-methods approach, the study will evaluate students' perceptions of AniHaven's usefulness in understanding emotions, practicing self-regulation, and recognizing when to seek timely support, while also assessing its accessibility and ease of navigation. With all of this, StudentHaven aims to provide adolescents aged 12-15 with the help they need to understand and regulate their emotions, while also knowing when it is the best time to seek support from adults/professionals.

Appendixes:

1. **AniHaven Website:** https://sites.google.com/dlsu.edu.ph/anihaven-gcu?usp=sharing

   DISCLAIMER: The journal feature on the AniHaven website is accessible only through official school (DLSU-IS) Google accounts to help protect students' privacy.

2. **Feedback Google Form:** https://forms.gle/fwqb6aYYmMay4nVZ9

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